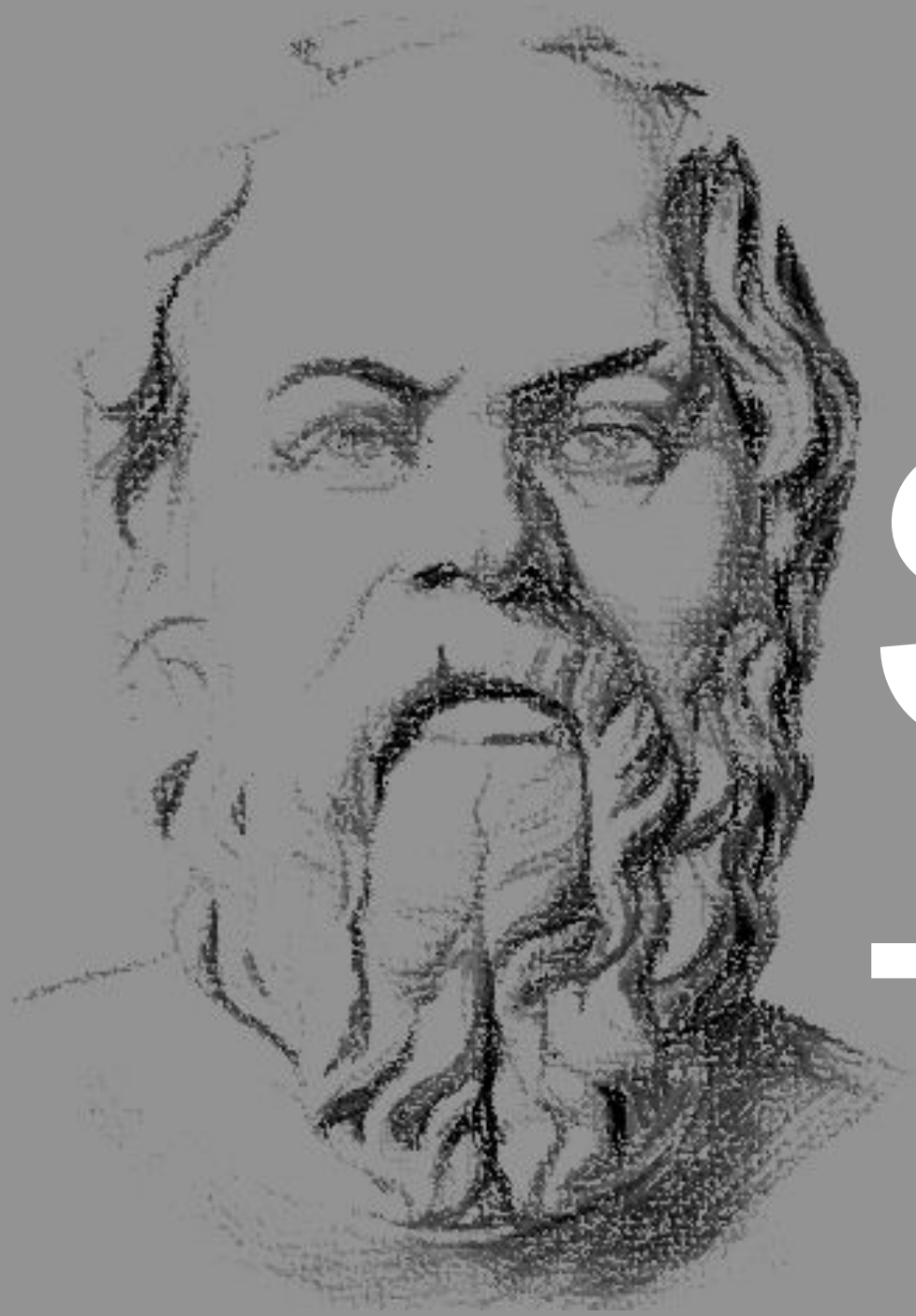
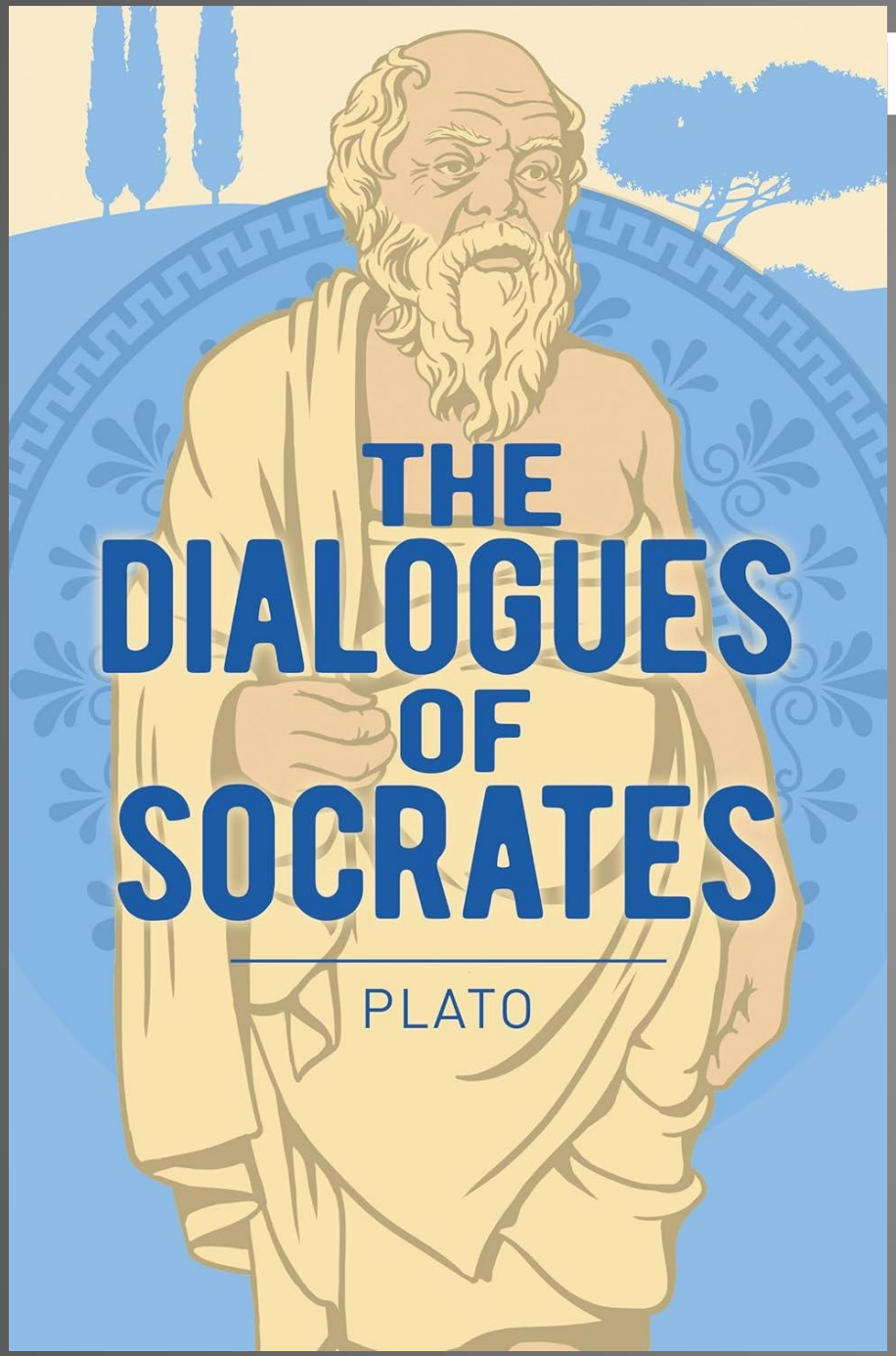


SOCRATES



The Philosophy of Socrates

"The unexamined life is not worth living."

- Socrates (469–399 BC) – founder of Western philosophy.
- Known through students like Plato and Xenophon.
- Wrote nothing himself; ideas survive through dialogues.

The Trial and Death of Socrates

Jacques-Louis David, 1787

- Accused of corrupting the youth and impiety.
- Chose death rather than betray his beliefs.
- Drank the hemlock in 399 BC.
- Symbol of moral courage and intellectual integrity.

The Legacy of Socratic Thought

- Inspired Plato – Theory of Forms, The Republic.
- Influenced Aristotle’s ethics and rational inquiry.
- Echoed in modern thinkers: Descartes, Kant, Kierkegaard.
- Socrates = Philosophy as a way of life.

Why Socrates Is Important

- Shifted focus from nature to human ethics.
- Asked: 'How should we live?' instead of 'What is the world made of?'
- Brought philosophy into everyday life.
- Explored virtue, justice, and the soul.

The Socratic Method

- Also called the Dialectic or Elenchus.
- Taught by asking questions, not giving answers.
- Revealed contradictions in beliefs.
- Led to deeper understanding and self-awareness.

Socratic Methods: Key Concepts

Socrates used three main techniques in his philosophy:

- 1. Dialectic or Elenchus
- 2. Maieutic
- 3. Aporia

Dialectics

Art of thinking and discussing logically through questions and answers

- Origin: Greek 'dialektiké' = art of conversation or discussion
- Meaning: Logical discussion between two or more people
- Goal: Not to 'win', but to reach truth through questioning
- Used by Socrates to examine concepts like justice, courage, virtue
- Method: Question → Answer → Clarification → Understanding

Elenchus (Refutation)

- Greek: ἔλεγχος, meaning examination or refutation
- Method of questioning to reveal contradictions in beliefs
- Not to humiliate, but to stimulate critical thinking
- Leads to awareness of one's ignorance

“The only true wisdom is in knowing you know nothing.”

Aporia (Perplexity)

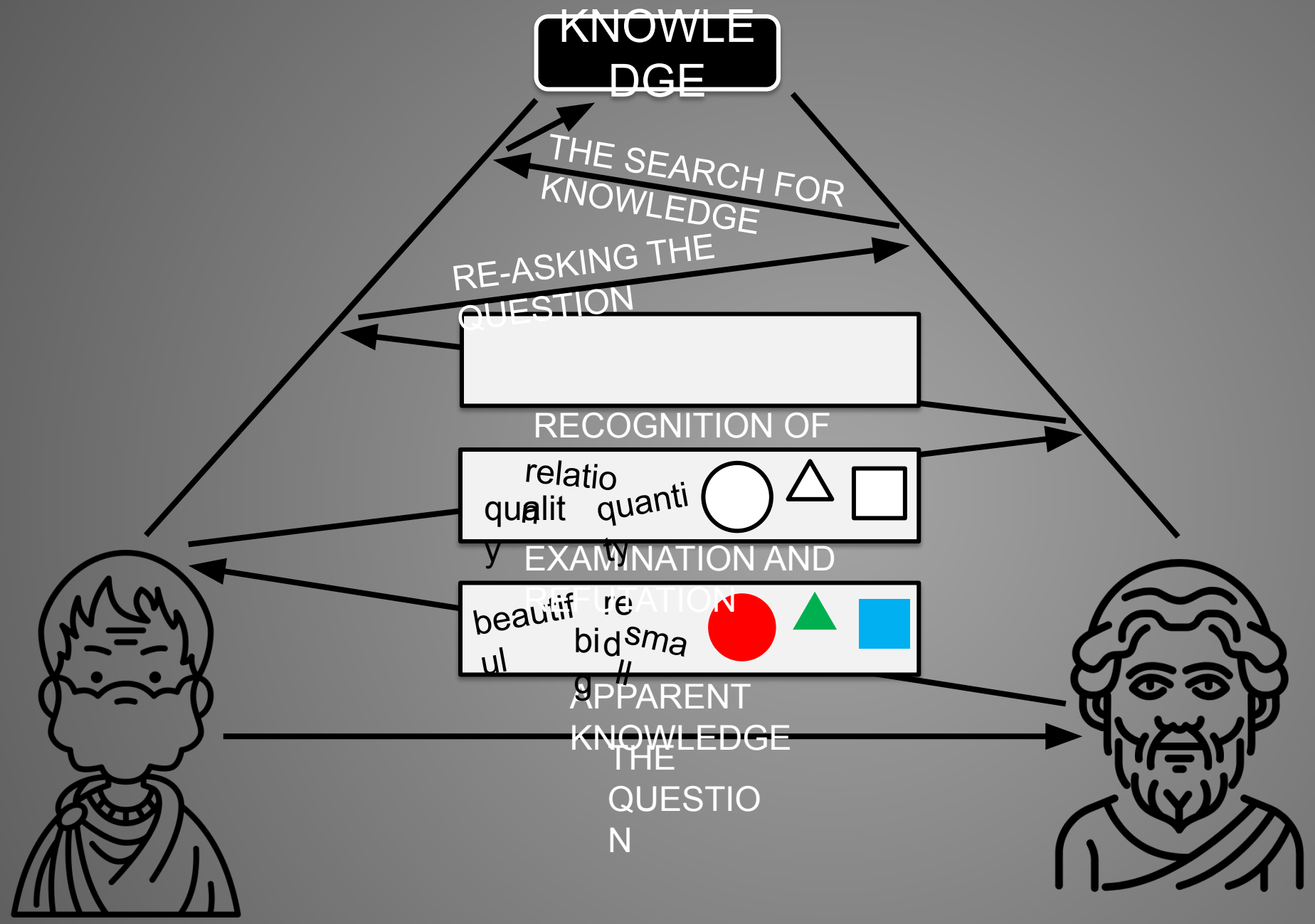
- Greek: ἀπορία, meaning puzzlement or impasse
- State of intellectual confusion following Socratic questioning
- Marks the recognition of one's ignorance
- Starting point for genuine philosophical inquiry

Maieutic Method (Midwifery of Ideas)

- Greek: maieutikē, meaning 'art of helping give birth'
- Guides interlocutors to discover truth within themselves
- Constructive questioning after Elenchus exposes ignorance
- Truth is latent in every soul and emerges through dialogue

“I am a midwife of the mind. I help others to give birth to their thoughts.”

CONCEPT	MEANING	FUNCTION
Elenchus	Refutation through questioning	Exposes false beliefs and contradictions
Aporia	State of puzzlement	Marks the start of real wisdom
Maieutic	Midwifery of ideas	Helps bring out true understanding



SELF-KNOWLEDGE

WILLINGNESS TO LEARN

PUZZLEMENT (APORIA)

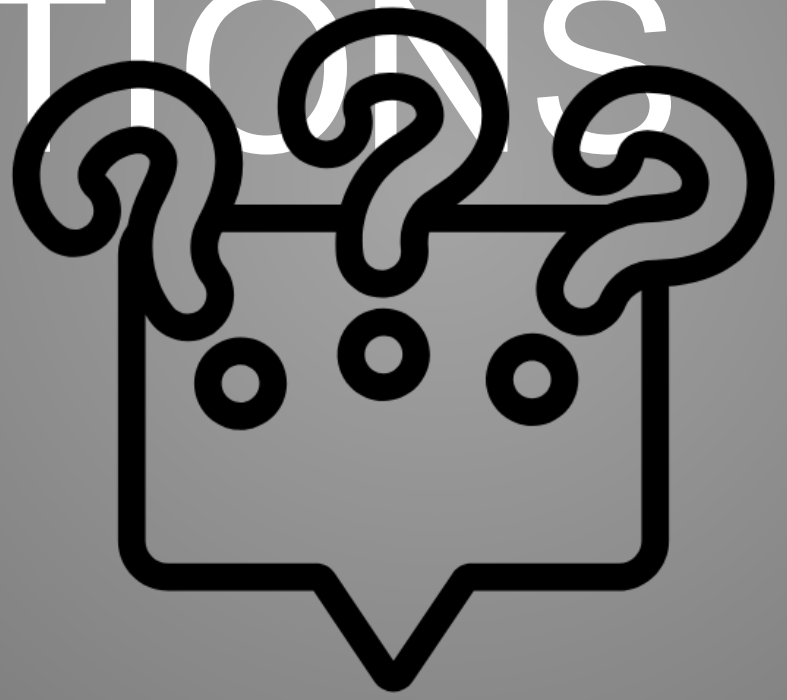
FALSE SELF-AWARENESS

Moral Knowledge and Virtue

- Knowledge = Virtue.
- People do wrong only out of ignorance.
- The key to moral life: Know yourself.
- True wisdom leads to a virtuous life.

“Know thyself.”

ASKING EFFECTIVE QUESTIONS



Question #1 – What do you mean by that?

Question #2 – How did you come to that conclusion?

Question # 3 - Have you ever considered…?

Example #1

Facilitator: You said, *“I only believe what can be demonstrated by science.”* What do you mean by that?

Student: I mean that I don’t accept anything unless science can prove it.

Facilitator: How did you come to that conclusion?

Student: I’ve seen a lot of claims that turned out to be false, so I think science is the most reliable way to know what’s true.

Facilitator: Have you ever considered that some things might be true – even if science can’t prove them?

Facilitator: Well, things like logical principles—like 2 + 2 = 4—or moral ideas—like “it’s wrong to hurt others”—aren’t proven by science in the same way, yet we accept them as true. What does that make you think about your original statement?
Student: I guess maybe science isn’t the only way to know what’s true.
Facilitator: What do you mean by that?
Student: That some truths might exist even if science can’t demonstrate them.
Facilitator: How did you come to realize that?
Student: By thinking about logic and ethics—they seem real even without scientific proof.
Facilitator: Have you ever considered that even science itself relies on some assumptions that can’t be fully proven?

Example #2

Facilitator: You said, *“AI will soon surpass human intelligence and might become a superintelligence that could do unpredictable things to humanity.”* What do you mean by that?

Student: I mean that AI is developing so fast that it might soon be smarter than all humans combined.

Facilitator: How did you come to that conclusion?

Student: I’ve seen many experts saying that AI is learning faster than people and that it could take control one day.

Facilitator: Have you ever considered that human intelligence might be more than just processing information or solving problems?

Facilitator: Well, humans also have consciousness, emotions, moral understanding, and creativity that AI doesn't really have. Does that change how you think about "surpassing human intelligence"?
Student: Maybe. I was thinking only about logical or computational power, not about the other aspects of intelligence.
Facilitator: What do you mean by "intelligence" then?
Student: I guess I meant technical or analytical ability, not the full human experience.
Facilitator: Have you ever considered that AI might not replace humans but instead expand human capacities—like a tool rather than a rival?

Discussion Questions

- 1. Why did Socrates prefer to ask questions instead of giving answers?
- 2. Do you agree that knowledge always leads to virtue?
- 3. How can we apply Socratic thinking in modern life?